It was in a deer park at Sarnath, just outside the city, that the Buddha delivered his first sermon. As an important crossroads the place was already an established hub of commercial and intellectual activity by this time, which is precisely what attracted him to it. Tourists visiting the Buddhist archaeological site at Sarnath often do not realize that the spot is sacred to other religious traditions too. Just outside, the visitor will see a large Jain temple dedicated to the eleventh 'tirthankara'. Similarly, the archaeological museum next door contains many idols and artifacts of the Brahminical tradition.

The place is still sacred to the devotees of Shiva. In fact, the name Sarnath is a short form for Saranganath (meaning 'Lord of the Deer') which is another name for Shiva. This should not be surprising as Varanasi has long been, and remains, a very important hub for Hindus of the Shaivite tradition. It may explain why the Buddha found a park with sacred deer at this place. Even today, there is a temple dedicated to Saranganath, less than a kilometre from the archaeological site. It is a small village temple that almost no tourist visits and is a peaceful place to linger in.

The intellectual innovations of the age were not limited to religious philosophy. For instance, the period also witnesses the systematization of Ayurveda, India's traditional medical system. A compendium compiled by Sushruta, who also lived near Varanasi, contains a long list of sophisticated surgical instruments and procedures. [13] There are detailed descriptions of plastic surgery, ophthalmic couching (dislodging of the lens of the eye), perineal lithotomy (cutting for bladder stones), the removal of arrows and splinters and the dissection of dead bodies for the study of anatomy. [14]

Unfortunately, most of this knowledge would be lost in the medieval era. Nevertheless, some techniques survived in isolated pockets and were witnessed by European visitors in the eighteenth century. This includes the famous 'rhinoplasty' operation that took place in Pune in March 1793 that would change the course of plastic surgery in Europe and the world. Cowasjee was a Maratha (more likely Parsi) bullock-cart driver with the English army during its campaigns against Tipu Sultan of Mysore. He was